of their positions along the border. This was not 1962 and the Chinese probably came to realize that after the exchange of fire at Nathu La.

In the late 1960s and early 1970s, the situation in Sikkim was becoming untenable for India: China was encroaching from the north; to the south of the Himalayan watershed, a second threat was posed by the Sikkimese ruler's quest for more independence; and then there was Naxalite activity in the strategically important Siliguri Neck just below the hills of Darjeeling. There were also intrigues within the Sikkim elite that had a destabilizing effect on the situation in this sensitive frontier area. Hope was certainly not a CIA agent, as some Indian tabloids had suggested. But she did not fit into Sikkimese society—and began to feel it. According to Datta-Ray, 'Hope's dream of queening it in the Himalayas cut off the *Chogyal* from his throne's traditional supporters and isolated him from Sikkimese society'.[32]

Hope had to compete for relevance with two other influential women: Thondup's sister Coocoola and Elisa-Maria Langford-Rae, the Scottish wife of Lhendup Dorji, a local landowner-turned-politician who came from an old Lepcha family. Nari Rustomji observed that 'Princess Coocoola saw in Hope a rival to her hold over the Prince, and Hope, in her turn, as soon made it clear that it was she, as Queen, who was the First Lady'.[33] Hope's contacts with powerful American senators prompted Coocoola to demonstrate to her brother that, 'she too was no less stalwart a champion of her country's cause. Her statements to the world press served however only to worsen the Prince's already sullied relations with the Indian authorities.'[34]

While the Indian journalists were speculating about Hope's possible CIA contacts, they forgot that it was Coocoola who had befriended American agents in Kolkata during and after World War II. But she was in her late teens and early twenties at that time and the agents she knew had most certainly already retired from active duty. Probably her main accomplishment in the U.S.A. was to arrange for two Sikkimese women to represent Sikkim at the Associated Country Women of the World conference in New York in 1967, a non-event for most Americans.

But there were concerns in India about possible American designs for Sikkim that could not be dismissed as tabloid gossip. After China's first nuclear test in 1964, a most peculiar, joint Indian-American espionage mission was undertaken in the Himalayas. The plan was to install a